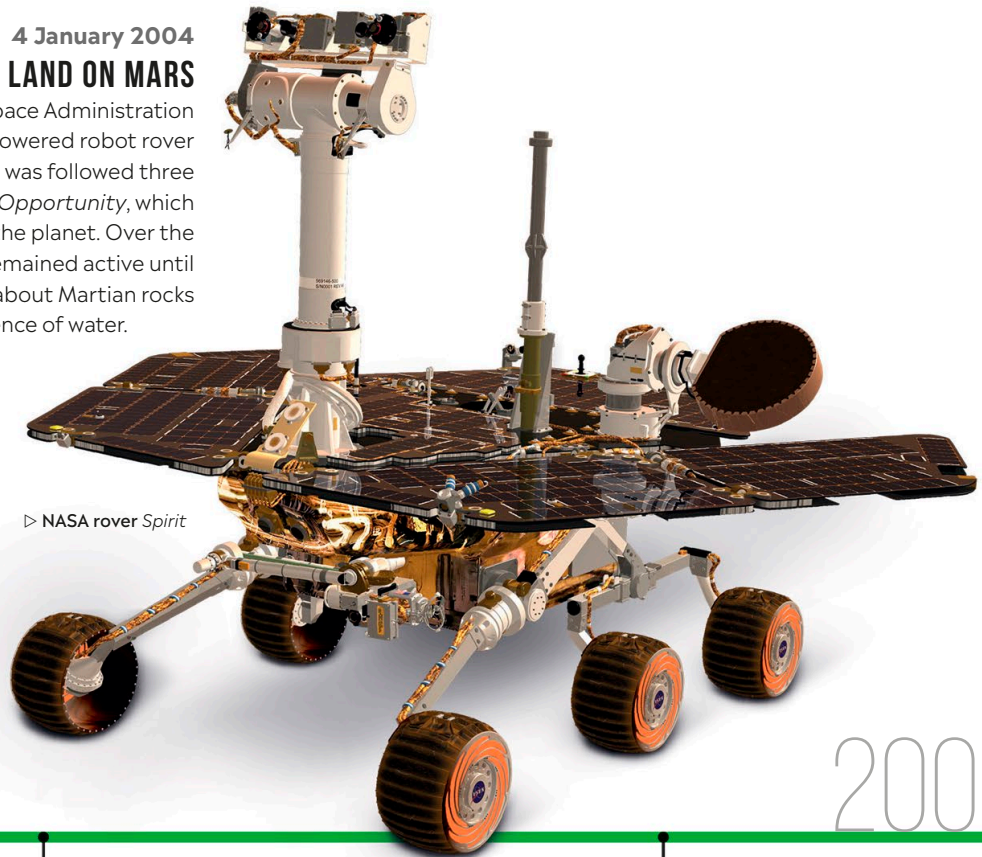


4 January 2004

NASA ROVERS LAND ON MARS

The US National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA) succeeded in landing the powered robot rover *Spirit* on the surface of Mars. It was followed three weeks later by its companion, *Opportunity*, which landed on the other side of the planet. Over the following years (*Opportunity* remained active until 2018) the rovers gathered data about Martian rocks and soils and searched for evidence of water.

▷ NASA rover Spirit



26 February 2003

Conflict breaks out in the Darfur region of western Sudan

2004

▽ US tanks in Iraq



20 March 2003

US-LED FORCES INVADE IRAQ

Claiming that Iraq's dictator Saddam Hussein possessed weapons of mass destruction which posed a threat to the West, US President George W. Bush assembled a group of allied powers to effect regime change. The military campaign was successful and Saddam was overthrown. However, civil strife spread in the power vacuum following his removal and dissidents launched a long-running insurgency against the occupying forces.

▽ Banda Aceh, Sumatra, after the tsunami



26 December 2004

INDIAN OCEAN TSUNAMI

Triggered by an undersea earthquake, the tsunami was the third-largest ever recorded, driving waves up to 30 m (100 ft) high onto coastal locations in Indonesia, Thailand, Sri Lanka, and southern India, as well as at least 10 other countries. In its wake it left an estimated 227,000 people dead, making it the most lethal such event so far recorded.